

Understanding Saptāṅga Theory as the Art of Governance: A Dharmaśāstric Approach to Polity and Statecraft

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Abstract

This paper examines the intricate framework of ancient Indian political thought as articulated through the *Saptāṅga* theory within *Dharmaśāstra* (DS) literature. It undertakes a critical analysis of the seven fundamental limbs of the state; *swāmī* (king), *amātya* (ministers), *janapada* (territory and population), *durga* (fort or capital), *kośa* (treasury), *daṇḍa* (army or force), and *mitra* (allies), tracing their conceptualization and evolution in *dharmaśāstric* tradition. The paper emphasises how DS texts underscore the interdependence and ethical responsibilities inherent in each *aṅga*, highlighting the dual functions of *daṇḍa*; disciplinary as well as protective, and delineate the king's role as a dharmic sovereign. By collating and systematically analysing relevant textual references, the paper demonstrates that DS presents a vision of political organisation that is deeply value-oriented yet pragmatically grounded, one that seeks to secure both the stability of the state and the preservation of moral order. Employing a rigorous textual evidence-based analysis, the study illuminates how these elements collectively underpin the ethical, legal, and administrative dimensions of governance rooted in *dharma*. It investigates the nuanced role of *dharma* as the moral foundation shaping political authority and statecraft, thereby bridging the realms of law, ethics, and power in ancient Indian polity. This research thus contributes to a broader understanding of ancient Indian political philosophy by showing how juridical and normative texts complemented theoretical models like the *saptāṅga* in defining the ideal structure and conduct of governance. Ultimately, this study enriches discourse on the integration of traditional jurisprudence with political administration, offering valuable insights for scholars of ancient political philosophy, legal history, and governance systems.

Keywords: *Saptāṅga*, *Swāmī*, *Amātya*, *Rāṣṭra*, *Durga*, *Kośa*, *Daṇḍa/Bala*, *Mitra*, *Dharmaśāstra* (DS)

INTRODUCTION

Polity, in its most fundamental sense, refers to the organised structure of political authority, institutions, and principles through which collective life is governed. While philosophers and political theorists from Aristotle to contemporary scholars have debated its constitution, most traditions agree that polity is neither a mere apparatus of power nor a set of institutions alone, but rather a complex order that balances authority, legitimacy, and the welfare of the community. In Aristotle's *Politics*, for instance, the polity (*politeia*) was conceived as a "mixed constitution" integrating elements of oligarchy and democracy into a balanced form of governance. In later Western traditions, polity evolved into conceptions of the *state* as seen in Roman law, medieval jurisprudence, and the modern social contract models of Hobbes, Locke, and Rousseau. Across civilisations, whether in Confucian political order in China, Islamic *siyāsa* traditions,

or African clan-based governance, the idea of polity has always been tied both to power structures and to normative visions of justice and order.

The Indian political imagination likewise developed distinctive frameworks for understanding polity, deeply intertwined with cultural, ethical, and metaphysical notions of *dharma*. From the Vedic age onwards, governance was rarely articulated as a mere exercise of authority; it was envisaged as a sacred duty, wherein kingship carried both the practical obligation to ensure material security and the moral responsibility to uphold cosmic and social order. The study of ancient Indian political thought has long been dominated by the celebrated *Arthaśāstra* (AS) of Kauṭilya, with its pragmatic and often unsentimental approach to questions of statehood, sovereignty, and governance. Yet, alongside the AS, an equally rich corpus, the *Dharmaśāstras* (DS) provides profound insights into the constitution and functioning of the state. It is one of the most important genres of Sanskrit literature. It refers to a body of texts that present a comprehensive system of laws, moral duties, ethics, and social norms, intended to govern both individual and collective life according to the principles of *dharma*, the foundational concept of righteousness, justice, and moral law in Indian thought. The term “*Dharmaśāstras*” is derived from two Sanskrit words: *Dharma*, meaning duty, righteousness, or moral order, and *śāstra*, meaning treatise, science, or instruction. Together, DS means a systematic treatise on *dharma*. The DS texts are not merely religious or ritualistic guides; they are profound documents of social, legal, and political philosophy. They contain rules related to personal behaviour (*achara*), social obligations, judicial procedures (*vyavahāra*), and atonement for sins (*prāyaschitta*). These texts attempt to regulate all aspects of life, spiritual, social, and political, by aligning them with *dharma*. AS offers a strategic manual of power politics, DS embeds its vision of polity within a normative, juridical, and moral framework that ties political authority inseparably to *dharma*. The following major traditions of Indian statecraft, the epics (*Mahābhārata* and *Rāmāyaṇa*), and later commentarial traditions, all wrestled with the tension between pragmatic survival of the state and ethical imperatives of *dharma*.

Within the broader landscape of ancient political thought, the *saptāṅga* theory stands out as one of the most enduring conceptualisations of polity. The term *saptāṅga* is derived from two Sanskrit words, *sapta* (seven) and *aṅga* (part or limb). Just as the human body is sustained by the coordinated functioning of its vital organs, the state (*rājya*) is conceived as an organic whole composed of seven essential elements. Systematised most notably in AS, the theory identifies these seven “limbs” (*aṅgas*) as: *swāmī* (the king), *amātya* (the ministers), *janapada* (the territory and its people), *durga* (the fortified capital), *kośa* (the treasury), *daṇḍa* (the army or coercive authority), and *mitra* (allies). Much like a living organism cannot survive in the absence of harmony among its parts, the state cannot endure without the interdependent functioning of these components.

While the theory is conventionally associated with the AS, this study contends that the *dharmaśāstric* tradition also articulates a distinctive rendering of the *saptāṅga* model; one that goes beyond administrative pragmatism to offer a value-laden vision of polity. The DS texts emphasise the interdependence and ethical responsibilities of each *aṅga*, underscore the disciplinary as well as protective role of *daṇḍa*, and portray the king as a *dharmic* sovereign whose authority derives not only from coercive power but equally from moral responsibility. In doing so, they imagine the state simultaneously as a normative and practical order, a polity conceived as a moral organism, yet firmly rooted in the pragmatics of governance and the imperatives of political stability. Within the broader landscape of ancient political thought, the *saptāṅga* theory stands out as one of the most enduring conceptualisations of polity. The term *saptāṅga* is derived from two Sanskrit words: *sapta* (seven) and *aṅga* (part or limb). Just as the human body is sustained by the

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THE ORGANIC STATE: COMPARATIVE PERSPECTIVES ON POLITY

The conception of the state as an organic whole, a living entity composed of interdependent parts, has surfaced in multiple civilisational traditions. The Indian *saptāṅga* theory, with its imagery of the polity as composed of seven vital limbs (*aṅgas*), reflects a worldview where governance is not mechanical but organismic; the health of the whole is conditional upon the integrity and harmonious functioning of its parts. This conceptualisation finds striking parallels in both classical Western and East Asian political thought, suggesting an archetypal human intuition about political community and social order.

Aristotelian Polis as an Organism: In Aristotle’s *Politics*, the *polis* is described not as an artificial structure but as a natural organism that comes into being “for the sake of life, but exists for the sake of the good life.” Just as the *saptāṅga* balances the functional roles of ruler, ministers, treasury, army, territory, forts, and allies, Aristotle emphasised the interplay between rulers, citizens, and laws as sustaining the organism-like polis. Both traditions conceive of polity not merely in terms of power acquisition, but as a morally infused, teleological order oriented towards societal well-being (Skinner, 1978).

Confucian Conceptions of the Body-Politic: Chinese Confucian thought also draws frequent analogies between political order and the human body. The ruler is often likened to the “heart” or “head,” ministers to the “hands,” and people to the “feet.” Harmony (*he*) among all parts ensures vitality, while disorder in one organ imperils the whole. In Confucian philosophy, governance is grounded in ethical responsibility (*ren*, benevolence) and ritual order (*li*), just as the *dharmaśāstric* vision ties polity to the moral obligations of *dharma*. Both traditions prioritise ethical responsibility over mere coercive power. The Confucian emphasis on familial hierarchy as a model for the state resonates with the *dharmaśāstric* view where the king, like a father, is obliged to protect and discipline subjects while securing justice and order (Legge, 1971).

Roman and Medieval Organic Analogies: In Roman law and later medieval European thought, the state too was described as a *corpus mysticum* (mystical body), with the king as the head and society as its members (Ullmann, 1975). This organic metaphor was used to justify both authority and responsibility. When compared with the *saptāṅga*, what stands out is India’s privileging of ethical legitimacy; the king’s role is not only coercive (*daṇḍa*) but dharmic, stressing justice and responsibility towards cosmic and social order.

Across these diverse traditions, the political community was understood not simply as an aggregation of power or a contractual arrangement, but as a living organism sustained by interdependence, ethical obligation, and ordered harmony. The *saptāṅga* theory thus belongs to a wider, trans-civilisational mode of thinking where governance is seen as organismic: each component of the state is both functionally necessary and morally bound to the whole. While the AS treatment of *saptāṅga* highlights strategic statecraft, the *dharmaśāstric* articulation offers a vision closer to Confucian and Aristotelian paradigms, where polity is not only about survival but about sustaining the moral fabric of society.

OBJECTIVES OF THE STUDY

To examine the *saptāṅga* theory within DS texts and trace how the seven limbs of the state (*swāmī*, *amātya*, *janapada*, *durga*, *kośa*, *daṇḍa*, and *mitra*) are conceptualised and integrated into the normative framework of *dharma*.

To analyse the distinctiveness of the *dharmaśāstric* articulation of polity in contrast to the AS, highlighting the former's emphasis on ethical responsibility, interdependence of limbs, and the king's role as a dharmic sovereign.

To explore the moral dimension of statecraft in DS literature, particularly the dual functions of *daṇḍa* (disciplinary and protective) and the ethical foundations of political legitimacy.

To demonstrate how juridical-normative texts contribute to ancient Indian political philosophy, showing that they do not merely prescribe moral conduct but also develop sophisticated visions of governance and polity.

To contribute to contemporary scholarship on political theory and legal history by recovering the *saptāṅga* theory in DS texts as a value-laden yet pragmatically grounded model of governance that bridges ethics, law, and statecraft.

METHODS

This paper employs a qualitative, textual, analytical methodology grounded primarily in the careful examination and interpretation of Sanskrit DS texts. The research is structured around the following methodological steps:

Primary Textual Analysis: The core of this research involves systematic analysis of the DS and the AS, with particular attention to references to the *saptāṅga* theory and its related concepts of statecraft and governance. Key texts examined include the *Manusmṛti* (MS), *Yājñavalkya Smṛti* (YS), *Śukranīti* (SN), *Nāradaśmṛti* (NS) and various relevant *āgamic* and *smṛti* sources. The study carefully analyses original Sanskrit verses, their semantic nuances, and contextual interpretations to uncover how each *aṅga* is conceptualised within normative political theory.

Comparative Textual Examination: To highlight distinctive and shared elements, these Dharmaśāstric conceptualisations are juxtaposed with the *saptāṅga* formulations in AS. This comparative lens facilitates identification of differences in emphasis, normative-ethical versus strategic-administrative and enriches the understanding of the theory's evolution and applications.

Thematic Synthesis: Insights from textual and comparative analyses are synthesised to construct a coherent account of how DS texts conceptualise polity, the state, and legitimate rule.

Ethical and Hermeneutic Considerations: The study respects the integrity of the primary texts, avoiding anachronistic readings, and applies hermeneutic principles that account for historical, linguistic, and cultural specificity. Interpretations are cross-verified with established commentarial traditions where available.

SAPTĀṄGA THEORY

These seven limbs form the structural and functional basis of governance in ancient Indian political thought and are discussed extensively across several DS texts. The traditional components includes: *Swāmī* (The ruler or king), *Amātya* (Ministers or administrators), *Rāṣṭra/Janapada* (the territory or domain of the state, along with its people), *Durga/Pura* (forts or defensive structures and the capital), *Kośa* (the treasury or financial resources), *Daṇḍa/Bala* (the army or coercive authority) and *Mitra* (allies or friendly states).

According to SN, the *saptāṅga* model is symbolically compared to the parts of the human body: the king (*Swāmī*) is the head, the minister (*Amātya*) the eyes, allies (*Mitra*) the ears, the treasury (*Kośa*) the mouth, the army (*Daṇḍa*) the mind, and the fort (*Durga*) and territory with people (*Janapada*) represent the hands and legs, respectively¹. The AS refers to each *aṅga* as *prakṛti*², while the MS uses the term *saptaprakṛti* synonymously with *saptāṅga*. Thus, although the terminology varies, *rāṣṭra* or *jana* for *janapada*, *bala* for *daṇḍa* and *pura* for *durga*, the fundamental idea remains consistent: these are essential, interdependent elements of statecraft (Shastri, 2018).

Notably, the sequence and nomenclature of these elements differ among key texts. The AS and YS list *janapada* before *durga*, *kośa*, and *daṇḍa*, whereas the MS alters this order, positioning *janapada* after these elements. Such variations attest to both the adaptability and the evolving theoretical landscape of Indian polity across time. Additionally, various texts employ different terms to denote the same foundational concepts of the state. For instance, *Rāṣṭra* or *Jana* is frequently used in place of *Janapada* to refer to the territory and population. *Bala* serves as another term for *daṇḍa*, emphasising the aspect of military force or coercive authority. Similarly, *Pura* is sometimes substituted for *Durga*, both terms indicating the capital or fortified centre of the state.

In some instances, the framework even expands: for example, the *Mahābhārata* (*Āśramavāsika Parva*, 5.8) describes a model of eight *aṅgas*, reflecting an ongoing flexibility and responsiveness in the development of ancient Indian political theory according to shifting historical and philosophical contexts.

Ancient Indian thinkers maintained that a legitimate state required not just a ruler and territory, but also a stable population and robust administrative apparatus (Altekar 1958). Early *sūtras*, such as those of Gautama and Āpastamba (Pandey, 2016), clearly articulate these elements, *rājā* (sovereign), *amātya* (administrative system), *rāṣṭra* (defined territory), and *prajā* (stable population), underscoring a nuanced understanding of order, security, and governance in early Indian political thought (Kane 1946).

With this foundation established, we now proceed to discuss each of the seven elements individually, highlighting their distinct roles and significance in classical statecraft.

Swāmī: Kingship, or monarchy, constituted the predominant and widely accepted form of governance in ancient India, with the king often identified as synonymous with the state itself. In Kautilya's *Arthaśāstra*, the king (*rājā* or *swāmī*) is articulated as the supreme authority within the polity, embodying its unity and sovereignty (Choudhary 1971). The necessity of a ruler is underscored in numerous ancient sources; for instance, the *Aitareya Brāhmaṇa* (I.14) narrates that the gods, confronted with disorder and disunity, collectively appointed a sovereign to re-establish order. Similarly, the MS posits that the Creator ordained the king for the protection of the world, highlighting the essential nature of governance. Most DS texts

¹ SN 1.63-64

² AS 6.1 & MS 7.294

invoke the principle of *Matsya Nyāya* (the Law of the Fish), an allegory illustrating that without a sovereign authority, the strong subjugate the weak³, thereby necessitating the presence of a ruler who wields *daṇḍa* (punishment or coercive power) judiciously to prevent disorder and uphold justice.

According to Chanakya, the welfare of the people was the ultimate foundation of the king's contentment, positioning the subjects as the primary beneficiaries of his benevolent rule (Rangarajan, 1992). While emphasising the king's paramount role as the ruler, Chanakya also underscored the critical importance of maintaining close connections with the populace to prevent the excesses of despotism and the burden of exorbitant taxation. He argued that upholding *dharma*, the moral and ethical code guiding governance, was contingent upon the king's knowledge, self-restraint, and prudent administration. This framework situates the king not merely as an autocratic sovereign but as a responsible custodian of the people's welfare, whose legitimacy and happiness derive directly from the well-being of his subjects.

It goes on to say that the Creator proceeded to create *daṇḍa* (the power of punishment) for the sake of the king, and that if the king does not sedulously employ danda for punishing those who deserve it. This example shows why having a ruler is important to stop disorder and make sure everyone is treated fairly.

Regarding qualifications for kingship, the MS begins its discourse on *rājadharmā*, the duties and responsibilities of a king⁴ by asserting the suitability of a *kṣatriya* who has undergone the *upanayana samskāra* (sacred thread ceremony) to assume the role of protector of the realm. This affirms that the ideal sovereign is one grounded in established dharmic and social duties, with protection (*rakṣaṇa*) of the people as central to kingship. Historical evidence also suggests some fluidity; while multiple Brahmin families established dynasties such as Puṣyamitra's Śuṅga Empire, figures like Gopāla, founder of the Pāla dynasty, hailed from the *Śūdra* varṇa. The MS prescribes that Brahmins should not reside in territories governed by the *Śūdra*⁵, reflecting social hierarchies but also indicating the complexities surrounding rulership.

The divine dimension of kingship is emphasised in MS, where the king is said to embody the powers of eight deities, Indra, Vāyu, Yama, Sūrya, Candra, Agni, Varuṇa, and Kubera, symbolising majesty, brilliance, valour, victoriousness, liberality, purity, control, and prosperity⁶. This sacred investiture situates the monarch as a representative of cosmic order, with *dharma* as his indispensable companion, embodied in the power of punishment (*daṇḍa*). Texts like NS further reinforce this theological underpinning, asserting that the king is the earthly manifestation of Indra⁷, endowed with divine authority to maintain justice. Encyclopaedic commentaries such as those by Āchārya Katyāyana describe the king as the protector of the helpless and the guardian of social order.

Etymologically, the term *rājan*, derived from the root *rāj*, originally signifies “to shine,” portraying the king as a radiant figure. The *Mahābhārata*

*sarīṣṛpebhyah stenebhyo na cānyonyātkadācana.
bhayamutpadyate tatra tasya rājño 'bhirakṣaṇāt. (Śānti Parva 59.125)*

offers an alternate interpretation, linking the king's title to the verb *rañj*, “to please” or “delight,” thus emphasising his role as a benevolent ruler concerned with the welfare of his subjects. The educational

³ AS 1.13, KNS 2.40,

⁴ MS 7.1

⁵ MS 4.61

⁶ Ms 7.4

⁷ NS 20

prerequisites for kingship include mastery of the fourteen *vidyās*, comprising the *Vedas*, *Vedāṅgas*, *Mīmāṃsā*, *Nyāya*, DS, and AS, which equip the sovereign with the knowledge necessary for righteous governance⁸ and effective administration.

The duties and rights of the king detailed in DS encompass the protection of the people, adjudication of justice, preservation of the *varṇāśrama* system, expansion of the treasury (*kośa*), and defence of the state from invaders. Kauṭilya classifies invaders into three types: *dharmavijayin* (conquerors for righteous cause), *lobhavijayin* (motivated by desire for material gain), and *asuravijayin* (those who resort to cruelty and destruction), underscoring the ethical nuances in warfare and conquest. AS advises rulers to restore the defeated monarch's family and territory wherever possible, reflecting obligations towards ethical conduct even in victory (AS VII.16). Complementarily, YS stresses respect for the customs and laws of conquered territories, reaffirming the moral responsibilities of rulers.

Amātya: The second essential element in the Saptāṅga theory of the state is the *Amātya*, commonly translated as “minister” or “administrator.” While generally referring to ministers, Kautilya uses the term *Amātya* in a broader sense to denote the Council of Ministers. *Dharmaśāstric* literature employs three Sanskrit terms to describe ministers—*Amātya*, *Śaciva*, and *Mantrin*. Among these, *Amātya* is the oldest and most frequently encountered across early texts. According to the *Arthaśāstra* (AS), the *Mantrin* holds a higher position with greater influence than the *Amātya*, who typically functions as an executive officer or advisor. Conversely, the MS treats *Śaciva* and *Amātya* synonymously, referring to the king's key assistants in governance.

Kautilya conceptualises the *Amātyas* as a formal cadre of state functionaries whose importance as counsellors, advisors, and aides to the king is profoundly emphasised. Drawing a vivid analogy, Kautilya states that a state's affairs cannot be conducted by the king alone, just as a carriage cannot move forward with only one wheel; hence, the king must rely on competent *Amātyas* and heed their counsel (Jindal, 2019). Thus, the ministerial class is considered second only to the king in importance, encompassing roles of both counsellors and departmental heads.

Since ancient times, considerable variation has existed regarding the ideal size of the council of ministers. The AS and *Kāmandakānītisāra* cite differing prescriptions: the Mānava school recommends twelve *amātyas*; the Bārhaspatyas advocate for sixteen; while Śukrācārya proposes a council of twenty ministers. However, Kauṭilya himself posits that the number of ministers should be flexible, contingent upon the state's strength (*śakti*) and exigencies (*āpada*). Furthermore, the *Śāntiparva* (85.7-9) of the *Mahābhārata* recommends a council comprising thirty-seven ministers (*sacivas*), with representation drawn proportionally from various social groups: four learned *Brāhmaṇas*, eight valiant *Kṣatriyas*, twenty-one capable *Vaiśyas*, three *Śūdras*, and one *Sūta*. This composition illustrates an inclusive and balanced framework that integrates diverse societal sections, thereby emphasising the importance of both wisdom and practical governance in state administration. Kautilya prescribes that the king should appoint precisely three or four counsellors, not fewer, lest control be difficult, nor more, which would jeopardise secrecy in counsel (Tiwari, 2017). He places ultimate authority in decision-making firmly in the king's hands. Furthermore, Kautilya differentiates *Amātyas* by quality: those of noble birth, firm determination, wisdom, eloquence, loyalty, and other virtues were fit to become prime ministers, while those with lesser qualifications might be assigned to lesser offices, such as overseeing mines, forests, or the elephant corps. Before appointment, candidates underwent rigorous tests assessing righteousness (*dharma*), wealth (*artha*), desire (*kāma*), and fear (*bhaya*), with comprehensive success required for ministerial posts.

⁸ SN 1.155

According to Kauṭilya (AS I.10), *amātyas* were tested through “*upādhas*” trials based on dharma (righteousness), *artha* (wealth), *kāma* (desire), and *bhaya* (fear). Those who successfully pass the *Dharma Upādha* are appointed to the judicial system; those who clear the *Artha Upādha* are assigned roles related to taxation and treasury. Candidates passing the *Kāma Upādha* serve as protectors of the queen, while those who pass the *Bhaya Upādha* become aides or personal attendants of the king. Those who successfully passed all four *Upādhas* were deemed qualified to serve as ministers (*mantrins*) in the royal council.

In SN, Śukra delineates the specific roles and functions of ministers ranging from *pratinidhi* (representatives) to *dūta* (envoys), providing a detailed account of their responsibilities within the governance structure⁹. Further, SN describes the arrangement of the king’s public durbar, emphasising the symbolic and hierarchical organisation of courtly space. The king is to be seated centrally in the western half of the hall, adorned with his crown, armour, and a drawn sword, signifying his sovereignty and martial readiness. Positioned behind him are his sons and grandsons; to his right sit his daughter’s sons; to his left, uncles, chief agnates, assembly members, and commanders¹⁰. The *mantrins* (ministers) and maternal relatives occupy the front to the right, while officers and in-laws are situated to the left, reflecting a carefully structured assembly designed to facilitate governance and counsel.

Rāṣṭra: The word *rāṣṭra* appears as early as the Ṛgveda (IV.42.1), where King *Trasadasyu* proclaims, “*mama dvitā rāṣṭraṃ kṣatriyasya*” meaning, “Mine is the kingdom on both sides (or in both realms).” According to Kāmandaka (VI.3), since all the elements of the state originate from its territory, the king must make every effort to strengthen and develop his realm. Similarly, the *Agnipurāṇa* (239.2) emphasises that among all the elements of the state, the *rāṣṭra* (territory) is the most important.

According to MS (VII.69), a king should establish his residence in a country that is not water-logged, is fertile and rich in crops, predominantly inhabited by cultured (*Ārya*) people, free from disturbances such as epidemics, pleasing in appearance due to its trees, flowers, and fruits, whose local chiefs have submitted to his authority, and where means of livelihood are easily available. According to Kāmandaka (IV.50-56), the prosperity of a kingdom is dependent on the quality of its soil. In ancient India, the modern sentiment of nationalism had hardly taken root. There was little sense of nationality in ancient India, and efforts towards fostering national unity were generally absent (Kane, 1946).

Kauṭilya states that within the kingdom, groups of villages should be organised around a central town or fort. A group of ten villages is called a *Sanḡrahaṇa*, a group of 200 villages is termed *Khārvaṭika*, 400 villages form a *Dronamukha*, and at the centre of 800 villages is established a *Sthānīya* a principal administrative or military center¹¹ (Ray & Sethy, 2020). Manu (VII.114) similarly states that the king should establish a *gulma*, a central post of guards in the midst of two, three, or five villages, and a *saṅgraha* in the midst of a hundred villages for maintaining law and order.

Durga: Manu places the capital even before the *rāṣṭra* (territory) in importance. Kullūka explains that the loss of the capital is a graver threat than the loss of some portion of the territory, since the capital houses essential supplies, the principal administrative elements, and the army. If the capital is preserved, it becomes possible to recover lost territory and protect the rest of the kingdom. Yājñavalkya states that forts are established for the protection of the king, the people, and the treasury¹² (Sharma, 2020).

⁹ SN 2.84-105

¹⁰ SN 1.353-361

¹¹ AS 2.1

¹² YS 1.321

Kauṭilya discusses in detail the construction of *durgas* (forts) and the layout of the capital within one of them¹³. He recommends that forts be constructed at the four boundaries of the kingdom in locations naturally suitable for offering resistance to enemies. He classifies forts into four types:

Āudaka: Protected by water; situated on an island or a plain surrounded by low ground and water.

Pārvata: Mountain fort; built on a rocky hill or within a cave.

Dhānvana: Desert fort; established in arid, waterless regions with dense thickets or wasteland.

Vana: Forest fort; located in forests abundant with water, reeds, and wagtails.

Kauṭilya notes that the first two types (*Āudaka* and *Pārvata*) are suitable for protecting densely populated areas, while the latter two (*Dhānvana* and *Vana*) are intended for safeguarding forest-dwelling communities. Ācārya Manu and Śukra mention six types of forts—*Dhanvadurga* (desert fort), *Mahīdurga* (land fort with stone or brick walls), *Jaladurga* (water fort surrounded by deep water), *Vṛkṣadurga* (forest fort with dense thorny vegetation), *Nṛdurga* (human fort guarded by a large army), and *Giridurga* (mountain fort with narrow access). MS considers the *Giridurga* (mountain fort) as the best among all due to its natural impregnability and strategic advantages¹⁴, while *Śānti Parva* (56.35) states that *Nṛdurga* is the most difficult to conquer. The king was expected to establish his capital either within a fortified structure or independently outside it, depending on strategic and geographical considerations.

Kośa: The *Kośa* (treasury) is recognised as one of the essential pillars of the state in ancient Indian political theory, consistently regarded as a crucial driver of governance, stability, and prosperity across several classical texts (Olivelle, 2013). Its significance is highlighted in diverse treatises on statecraft, each underscoring the centrality of a well-maintained treasury to the vitality and expansion of the realm.

The *Mahābhārata* affirms that both *kośa* and the army constitute the roots of all state development; the army safeguards the kingdom against internal and external threats, while the treasury is indispensable for sustaining the armed forces. The text further implies that the merits earned and welfare achieved by subjects flow from the king's capacity to maintain a strong and well-resourced treasury.

AS forcefully advances this view, asserting that “all things in this world depend upon *Kośa*; thus, prudent rulers must take utmost care to protect, nurture, and expand their fiscal resources. According to Kauṭilya, a prosperous treasury empowers a king to strengthen his kingdom, invest in welfare, and exert influence beyond his domain.

The MS also speaks to the imperative of a capable and resourceful king, it prescribes that the sovereign should both develop the treasury and expand his realm, establishing that the effectiveness and legitimacy of the government rest on the assured upkeep of material prosperity.

Likewise, Somadeva, in his *Nītivākyāmrta*, metaphorically describes the treasury as “the breath of the king's existence, not the air he breathes,” emphasising that sovereign power is rooted less in the person of the king and more in the financial health of the state.

Śukra, stresses that *kośa* is accumulated not only for the upkeep of the army but also for the welfare of the people and the performance of sacred sacrifices (Mishra, 2019). He concludes that “the treasury is the root of felicity in heaven and joy on earth,” thus situating *Kośa* as the foundation for both temporal and spiritual well-being.

¹³ AS 2.3-4

¹⁴ MS 7.71

Kauṭilya says that a king with an empty treasury troubles both city and village people¹⁵. He explains that all government work depends on the treasury, so the king should give first priority to maintaining it¹⁶. Kosa is the basis or support of the other six elements of the State. Kāmandaka states that it is commonly said that the king depends upon the treasury (Garg, 2016).

The primary source of revenue for the treasury was taxation. Therefore, it is important to understand the principles of taxation as laid down by ancient Indian scholars. According to the *smṛtis*, the king was not allowed to impose taxes arbitrarily. The rates of taxation were pre-determined by these texts and varied depending on the type of commodity and the circumstances, such as times of peace, invasion, or natural calamities. According to Manu (VII.130), the king was generally entitled to one-sixth of the grain or agricultural produce. However, Kautilya (V.2), Manu (X.118), the *Śāntiparva* (87), and Śukra (IV.2.9-10) permit the king to collect up to one-third or even one-fourth of the produce during times of distress (*āpada*). It is important to note that Kautilya advises the king to *request* (*yāceta*) rather than demand such heavy taxation from the people. He uses the term *praṇaya* (a respectful request) for this purpose¹⁷. Such taxation was not to be imposed on inferior lands, and Kautilya clearly states that even in times of distress, this exceptional tax should be levied only once, not repeatedly.

Taxes were to be collected at the proper time and place, as stated in *Śāntiparva* (88.12) and Kāmandaka (V.83-84). While taxing traders, the king was expected to consider several factors: the price paid for the goods, the likelihood of selling them within the kingdom, the distance over which the goods were transported, expenses on food and condiments, and the cost of securing the merchandise. This principle is outlined in Manu (VII.127) and reiterated in *Śānti Parva* (87.13-14). According to Manu, even a very poor person who sustains himself through any occupation should be asked to contribute annually a small amount as *kara* (a type of tax). Additionally, workers such as cooks, artisans like blacksmiths, and *Śūdras* who earn by manual labour (e.g., porters) should offer one day's work to the king each month¹⁸.

Kāmandaka (IV.62-64) states that the king's treasury (*kośa*) should have multiple sources of income but limited avenues of expenditure. It should be filled with all desirable forms of wealth, including pearls, gold, and jewels; safeguarded by trustworthy officials; acquired through lawful means; and capable of withstanding heavy financial demands. The treasury must be preserved to uphold *dharma* and *artha*, to support royal employees, and to serve as a reserve during crises. SN adds that the *kośa* is maintained for the army's sustenance, the welfare of the people, and the performance of sacrifices¹⁹. Various DS texts assert that taxation is intended for the protection of the people, and it constitutes the king's legitimate remuneration for the security and governance he provides²⁰.

Collectively, these perspectives establish *Kośa* as indispensable to the state's structural integrity. It supports military strength, facilitates public welfare, underpins religious and cultural functions, and embodies the material foundation of sovereignty. The recurrent emphasis on fiscal prudence and distributive welfare in these texts illustrates the depth and pragmatism of ancient Indian reflections on statecraft (Borah, 2019).

¹⁵ AS 2.1

¹⁶ AS 2.8

¹⁷ AS 5.2

¹⁸ MS 7.137-138

¹⁹ SN (IV.2.3)

²⁰ NS prakirnaka 48

Daṇḍa: Daṇḍa is one of the components of the *saptāṅga* theory of the state, signifying punishment, either corporal or monetary as well as the army with its four divisions²¹. The *Ṛgveda* contains numerous references to armies, weapons, and battles. In some *dharmashāstric* texts, *daṇḍa* is also referred to as *bala*. *Kām. (XIII.34-37)* states that a king with a strong financial position is able to replenish his diminished army, provide support to his subjects, and even command reliance from his enemies.

Most authorities concur that troops are classified into six types—*maula* (hereditary troops), *bhṛta* (hired soldiers), *śreṇī* (troops provided by guilds), *mitra* (forces from allies or feudatory states), *amitra* (former enemy soldiers now serving the king), and *āṭavika* or *ākṛtika* (irregular forces or wild tribes employed as troops). The first three sources affirm that each preceding category of troops is superior to the one that follows. *Maula* troops were equivalent to the modern standing army. The *Sabhāparva* (5.63) appears to mention four types of troops, omitting *śreṇī* and *amitra*. The *Yuddhakāṇḍa* (17.24) refers to five categories, excluding *śreṇī*. The *Āśramavāsikaparva* (68.7-8) enumerates five types, excluding *amitra*, and observes that *maula* and *mitra* forces are superior to the others, while *bhṛta* troops and *śreṇī* troops are considered equal in rank.

Unlike earlier teachers who believed that soldiers should be recruited according to caste order *Brāhmaṇas*, *Kṣatriyas*, *Vaiśyas*, and *Śūdras*. Kautilya believed that a strong army of trained *Kṣatriyas*, or even a larger force of *Vaiśyas* and *Śūdras*, was better than an army of *Brāhmaṇas*. He argued that enemies could easily influence *Brāhmaṇa* soldiers by showing them respect or bowing before them²². According to Kāmandaka (IV. 63, 65, 67), the hereditary army (*pitṛ-paitāmaha*) should primarily consist of *Kṣatriyas*. An army in ancient texts was considered to be made up of four main divisions—elephants, horses, chariots, and foot soldiers, known collectively as *caturaṅga bala* (four-fold army). According to Kautilya and Kāmandaka, the defeat of the enemy and the achievement of victory largely depended on the use of elephants in warfare²³. Vast armies were kept by ancient kings and emperors. The *Śukranītisāra* (II. 140-148) provides an alternative hierarchical structure for organising the army. According to this scheme, five or six infantry soldiers constituted a unit known as a *paṭṭi*, which was commanded by an officer termed *paṭṭipā*. Over thirty *paṭṭipās* was the *gaṭmika*, and above one hundred *gaṭmikās* was the *śatānīka*, a higher-ranking officer. The *śatānīka* was supported by three officials—the *anuśāsaka* (inspector or adjutant), the *senānī* (general), and a *lekhaka* (scribe or record keeper). Additionally, an officer known as *nāyaprakṣu* (possibly a precursor to the modern *naik*) was placed in charge of twenty elephants or cavalry units. Importantly, each officer was expected to wear a distinct insignia symbolising their rank and role within the military hierarchy.

Mitra: Manu emphasises the importance of forming alliances in MS VII.208, where he highlights the essential qualities of a good friend or ally for a king. He asserts that a ruler does not prosper merely through the acquisition of wealth or territory, but rather through the cultivation of steadfast and reliable friendships. In MS, it stated that land, wealth (gold), and a dependable ally are the three principal outcomes of royal policy (*rājanīti*), underscoring the centrality of alliances in the exercise of effective kingship. Yājñavalkya presents a view similar to MS. In contrast to the above view, Kautilya maintains that the acquisition of territory is superior to that of gold or allies, and that the acquisition of gold holds greater value than that of friendship (Kaur, 2010).

²¹ Daṇḍaḥ caturaṅga sainyaṁ na bhavati.... Sumantumate caturaṅgasainyasya kośa evāntarbhāvaḥ iti |

²² AS 9.2

²³ हस्तप्रधानो वज्रियी राज्ञाम् | (AS 2.2)

This subject of forming alliances naturally leads to the well-known *Maṇḍala* theory, that is of inter-state relations. Most DS texts discuss the theory of *Maṇḍala* and the six *guṇas* (strategic policies) in considerable detail. In the AS, the *Maṇḍala* theory comprises twelve elements—*arimitramitra*, *mitramitra*, *arimitra*, *ari*, *mitra*, *vijigīṣu*, *pārṣṇigrāha*, *ākṛanda*, *pārṣṇigrāhasāra*, *ākṛandasāra*, *madhyama*, and *udāsīna*. According to Kāmandaka, a *vijigīṣu* is a king who aspires to extend his territories, is endowed with all the seven elements of sovereignty (*saptāṅga*), possesses great energy, and engages in sustained and vigorous efforts. An *ari* (actual or potential enemy) refers to a king or group of kings who are the immediate neighbours situated along the outer boundary of the *vijigīṣu*'s kingdom. A *mitra* (friend of the *vijigīṣu*) is defined as a ruler whose territory is separated from that of the *vijigīṣu* by the intervening kingdom of the *ari* (enemy).

The aspiring king (*vijigīṣu*), after carefully assessing his three types of strength (*śakti*), strategically employs the six *guṇas* (methods of state policy). The framework of the twelvefold *maṇḍala* (circle of states) provides the contextual basis for the application of these six diplomatic measures. Kauṭilya defines the six *guṇas* as: *sandhi* (treaty), *vigraha* (hostility), *āsana* (neutrality), *yāna* (expedition), *saṁśraya* (seeking shelter), and *dvaividhibhāva* (dual policy of peace and war).

Review of Literature and Theoretical Framework

1. Survey of Scholarship on Saptāṅga Theory: The *Saptāṅga* theory has attracted significant scholarly attention as a cornerstone of ancient Indian statecraft. Most studies focus on its systematic exposition in AS, where the state is conceptualised as an assemblage of seven interdependent limbs (*aṅgas*) a sophisticated model widely regarded as emblematic of classical Indian political thinking. Scholars such as R. Shamasastri (Shamasastri, 1915), Patrick Olivelle, and Romila Thapar (Thapar, 2002) have analysed the origins, structure, and practical implications of the *saptāṅga* in the AS, emphasising its administrative rationality and strategic orientation. R. Shamasastri, who first translated and analysed the AS, foregrounded the “seven limbs” model as a pragmatic governance framework, where the state (*rājya*) is likened to a living organism. Prasain (Prasain, 2024), for example, emphasises that Kauṭilya's approach was not reductively materialistic—the king functions as a moral guardian, and the welfare of subjects remains a core objective of statecraft.

Modern scholarship recognises the AS as both practical and ethical, blending administrative sophistication with concern for justice and order. Studies by Romila Thapar and Patrick Olivelle further elaborate that, though the AS is famous for its “realist” politics, it is deeply attentive to the interdependence of the seven state elements, echoing the philosophies of Plato and Aristotle, who also viewed the polity as a functional whole.

In contrast, DS texts have received less attention as sources of political theory, often being approached primarily as juridical or ethical treatises. However, recent scholarship draws attention to their surprisingly nuanced political theory. P.V. Kane (1946) and B.K. Sarkar were early proponents of examining these texts for their contributions to Indian political thought, noting that the DS outlines obligations of the king, justice, social order, and even practicalities of administration and alliance-building. Donald Davis Jr. (Lubin et al, 2010) has contributed to reframing DS as more than a moral code, highlighting its engagement with the art of governance and the ethical duties of rulership.

2. Positioning the Present Study—Value-Oriented vs. Administrative Models: This paper situates itself at a critical intersection in the scholarship of ancient Indian political thought, addressing the often polarised characterisation of the *saptāṅga* theory within two predominant interpretative frameworks—the administrative-rational model primarily associated with AS, and the normative, value-oriented model emerging from the *dharmaśāstric* texts.

Traditional readings of the AS emphasise its pragmatic and strategic approach to governance. Kauṭilya’s treatise is widely revered as a comprehensive manual of statecraft, focusing on the mechanics of power, administrative efficiency, diplomacy, and warfare. In this view, the seven limbs (*aṅgas*) of the state are understood mainly as functional components essential for maintaining control, expanding influence, and securing the state’s survival. The model, though sophisticated in its political realism, is often portrayed as devoid of explicit ethical or moral aspirations, more concerned with outcomes and efficacy than with principled governance.

In contrast, the *dharmaśāstric* texts offer a different and complementary articulation of polity, one deeply invested in the ethical, legal, and moral dimensions of statecraft. This tradition foregrounds *dharma* not as a peripheral ideal but as the foundational principle guiding political organisation. The *saptāṅga* theory, as presented in the DS, is thus not merely an administrative blueprint but a vision deeply imbued with normative significance. Each limb of the state is conferred with ethical responsibilities that transcend mere function—the king (*swāmī*) is not simply a ruler but a *dharmic sovereign* whose legitimacy flows from his adherence to righteousness and justice; ministers (*amātya*) are moral advisors as well as administrators; the army (*daṇḍa*) serves both as a protective and disciplinary force, regulated by principles of fairness and necessity.

This study advances the argument that the *Dharmaśāstric saptāṅga* model envisions the polity as a moral organism, an integrated and interdependent system where the vitality of the whole relies on the ethical conduct and harmonious interaction of its parts (Sinha, 1962). Unlike purely strategic-administrative accounts, this perspective insists on the role of *dharma* as the ethical compass that not only constrains but also empowers governance. The state is imagined not just as a machine of power or coercion but as an ordered society rooted in justice, virtue, and social welfare.

By juxtaposing these two interpretative frameworks, the paper highlights the richness and complexity of ancient Indian political philosophy. It challenges reductive binaries between “realist” and “idealistic” understandings of the state, demonstrating that the *dharmaśāstric* tradition integrates instruments of power with a deep commitment to moral principles. This synthesis offers a holistic understanding of ancient Indian statecraft, one that weaves together legal norms, ethical obligations, and pragmatic governance into a coherent tapestry.

Moreover, by illuminating the value-laden dimensions of the *dharmaśāstric saptāṅga*, the paper responds to prevailing gaps in scholarship that have often marginalised or overlooked these texts as mere supplementary or moralistic commentaries. Instead, it positions the *dharmaśāstric* contributions as central to the ancient Indian conception of polity, emphasising their enduring relevance for contemporary reflections on the nexus of governance, law, and ethics.

In doing so, this study argues for a more nuanced appreciation of Indian political thought, one that recognises how governance was historically imagined as an ethical enterprise, inseparable from the duties and virtues of both ruler and subjects, and how this vision offers valuable insights into the perennial challenge of integrating morality with political authority.

The Moral Dimension of Statecraft in Dharmaśāstric Literature: Dual Functions of Daṇḍa and Ethical Foundations of Political Legitimacy

The DS corpus situates statecraft firmly within an ethical framework deeply intertwined with the concept of *dharma* the principle of cosmic order, righteousness, and social duty. Unlike purely pragmatic treatises that privilege power and administration, DS texts weave moral accountability and normative guidance into the very fabric of governance, reflecting a vision of political authority that is as much ethical as it is functional.

Central to this vision is the role of *daṇḍa*, understood as the instrument of punishment and coercion. However, *dharmaśāstric* texts articulate *daṇḍa* as embodying dual and complementary functions, both disciplinary and protective. This duality places the wielding of *daṇḍa* firmly within a moral order; it is not an end in itself but a means to uphold *dharma* within the state.

The disciplinary function of *daṇḍa* involves the enforcement of laws and social norms, serving as the corrective mechanism by which order is restored and maintained. Whether directed at individuals violating social codes or factions threatening political stability, *daṇḍa* acts as the instrument through which justice is administered impartially. The MS and other DS emphasise that punishment must be proportional, just, and situationally appropriate, underscoring the moral restraint that governs the use of political authority. Excessive or unjust use of *daṇḍa* is condemned, highlighting the ruler's ethical obligation to protect subjects from harm, including harm caused by the ruler himself.

Simultaneously, the protective function of *daṇḍa* manifests in the safeguarding of the polity from both internal disorder and external threats. The military and coercive powers are exercised not only to deter and punish wrongdoers but also to defend the state, ensure the security of its people, and preserve the welfare of the broader social order. This protective role is seen as essential to sustaining *dharma* and enabling the flourishing of society. The king, endowed with the mandate of governance, becomes the protector of his subjects, an ethical guardian whose coercive powers are circumscribed by this responsibility.

The ethical foundations of political legitimacy in *dharmaśāstric* thought hinge upon this virtuous exercise of *daṇḍa* and the wider observance of *dharma*. The king's legitimacy is not simply derived from hereditary succession or military power but fundamentally rests on his active commitment to righteousness, justice, and the welfare of the people. The DS describes the ruler as a *dharmaśāstra*, a sovereign whose authority is inseparable from his moral and legal duties. Failure to uphold *dharma* leads to the loss of legitimacy and eventual downfall, reinforcing the principle that power is contingent upon ethical governance.

This moral conception contrasts sharply with purely Machiavellian or realist notions of power (Prabhu, 2016). It situates the ruler within a cosmic and social order that demands accountability and balance. The king's role is both sacred and legal, requiring wisdom, compassion, and adherence to just principles. By grounding political authority in ethical conduct and regulated use of *daṇḍa*, Dharmaśāstric literature presents an integrated model of polity, one where law, morality, and power coalesce in the pursuit of social harmony and political stability (Singh, 1993).

In this way, *dharmaśāstric* statecraft affirms that coercive power is legitimate only when wielded ethically, reinforcing the broader *saptāṅga* vision of the state not merely as an administrative machine but as a moral organism, sustained through the balanced interplay of responsibility, discipline, and protection.

Contribution to Contemporary Scholarship: Recovering the Saptāṅga Theory as a Value-Laden yet Pragmatic Model of Governance

The rediscovery and analysis of the *saptāṅga* theory within *Dharmaśāstric* literature significantly enrich contemporary discourse in political theory and legal history by presenting a model of governance that is simultaneously moralistic and pragmatic. This recovery challenges prevalent narratives that often marginalise ancient Indian political thought to either metaphysical idealism or reductive realpolitik, positioning it instead as a sophisticated framework where ethics, law, and statecraft are integrally intertwined.

Contemporary political theory increasingly recognises the need to explore alternative, non-western conceptions of governance that transcend the limitations of dichotomies such as idealism versus realism or morality versus power. The *saptāṅga* theory as articulated in *Dharmaśāstric* texts offers precisely such a nuanced synthesis, where the legitimacy and functioning of the state are grounded in a normative foundation, the principle of *dharma*, without overlooking the exigencies of effective political administration and social order (Sharma, 1991).

By foregrounding this integrative model, the present study contributes to multiple scholarly conversations:

Bridging Ethics and Political Authority: Unlike many Western legal and political traditions that separate the realm of morality from that of governance, *Dharmaśāstric* formulations embed ethics deeply within the structures of governance. This presents a compelling example of how legal and political authority can be conceived as inherently ethical, where rulers are accountable not just to subjects but to transcendent moral codes that regulate power and justice. This is especially relevant in contemporary debates on ethical leadership and the moral limits of power.

Reframing Legal History: The study challenges conventional historiography which often sidelines Hindu DS as religious or ritualistic texts distinct from political law codes. Highlighting their contributions to the *saptāṅga* theory reveals their pivotal role in shaping legal doctrines that articulate governance principles, rules of punishment (*daṇḍa*), justice, rights, and duties, that formed the operative legal framework of ancient India. This recovery thus enriches the global history of legal thought by incorporating a complex indigenous tradition that balanced normative law with statecraft.

Deepening Understanding of Governance Models: Contemporary governance scholarship seeks models that reconcile normative values with pragmatic realities, enabling effective administration, social cohesion, and legitimacy. The *Dharmaśāstric saptāṅga* offers a classical exemplar of this balance, envisioning governance not as cold technocracy but as a holistic system where every element of the state (from treasury to alliance to military) functions within ethical constraints and mutual responsibilities.

Expanding Comparative Political Philosophy: Integrating the *dharmaśāstric saptāṅga* into comparative analyses disrupts Eurocentric hegemonies in political thought and legal theory. By articulating an Indian philosophical tradition that harmonises ethics, law, and political administration, it invites dialogue with other global traditions and affirms the plurality of traditions addressing common human concerns about power, justice, and social order.

Informing Modern Debates on Rule of Law and Ethical Sovereignty: Finally, as modern states grapple with challenges of legitimacy, justice, and the moral authority of power, revisiting ancient frameworks like the *Dharmaśāstric saptāṅga* provides historical insights that remain strikingly relevant. The model's

insistence that authority must be justified through ethical sovereignty and moral responsibility resonates with contemporary demands for accountable, just, and humane governance.

In sum, this study's recovery of the *saptāṅga* theory within the DS tradition thus constitutes a valuable contribution that deepens and broadens contemporary understanding of political theory and legal history, showcasing an enduring classical model that bridges ethics, law, and statecraft in a manner still instructive for the present.

DISCUSSION

The *saptāṅga* theory, rooted in ancient Indian political philosophy, continues to offer profound insights applicable to contemporary governance, geopolitics, and international relations. Its seven foundational elements remain relevant today in understanding the essential components that sustain effective states and communities.

In modern governance, the concept of leadership encapsulated by the *Swāmī* (king) underscores the critical need for competent, responsible, and accountable leadership in positions of authority. The role of the *Amātya* (ministers or administrators) highlights the indispensability of advisory bodies and bureaucratic institutions in decision-making processes, reflecting the structure of contemporary government systems. The notion of *Rāṣṭra* or *Janapada* (territory and population) affirms the ongoing importance of maintaining territorial integrity and national sovereignty in a globalised world (Mishra, 1973).

Regarding the protection of the state, the *Durga*, originally symbolising physical forts, translates today into advanced defence infrastructures, encompassing cybersecurity, strategic military installations, and disaster resilience measures. This evolution highlights the enduring necessity for safeguarding the state against diverse internal and external threats. Correspondingly, the *Kośa* (treasury) represents the financial backbone of the state; modern parallels include maintaining economic stability, prudent fiscal management, and fostering sustainable growth. Effective governance now demands rigorous financial administration to support public policy and social welfare programs.

National defence remains a pillar of sovereignty, with the *Danḍa*, the army or coercive power, representing the necessity of robust and professional security forces to uphold peace and protect national interests. On the international front, the concept of *Mitra* (allies) resonates strongly with contemporary diplomacy, emphasising the strategic importance of alliances, partnerships, and cooperative frameworks to address shared global challenges.

Together, these elements illustrate that the *saptāṅga* theory offers not only a historical template but also a timeless framework, one that underscores the synergy of leadership, administration, territorial control, defence, economic management, and diplomatic relations necessary for the stability and progress of any polity. As such, this ancient model provides enduring guidance for modern nation-building and governance.

The DS and allied ancient Indian political texts present a well-organised, multilayered, and pragmatic view of statecraft through the *saptāṅga* theory. This theory, comprising the 7 elements, provides a holistic framework for understanding the state as a dynamic organism. The texts do not treat these elements in isolation but emphasise their interdependence and collective role in maintaining sovereignty, justice, and order.

The king plays a central role in the functioning of the state. He collects taxes from the people to fill the treasury (*kośa*), ensures justice by administering punishment (*danḍa*) to wrongdoers, and appoints capable

ministers (*amatyas*) to his council. It is his duty to create a strong and prosperous kingdom (*rāṣṭra*) where people can live peacefully and safely. He is also responsible for developing and securing the capital (*durga*) to protect its inhabitants. All seven elements of the state-king, ministers, territory and population, fortified capital, treasury, army, and ally are interconnected, and this interconnectedness is demonstrated throughout this paper.

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